any sort of disarmament arrangement regardless of the implications for India.' Nehru believed that disarmament 'was very much in the interests of relatively weak powers like India' and 'hoped that the disarmament process would come to constrain India's rivals, particularly China.' [60] Further, Nehru's support for civilian nuclear energy and the work of Indian nuclear scientists demonstrated that he understood the need for India to have the requisite nuclear power potential just in case circumstances ever changed.

According to Murty, Nehru's foreign policy was 'cold and rationally calculated', bearing in mind that India, a country with 'pride in its glorious past and great civilization', was industrially and technologically backward and underdeveloped. Hence, democracy at home and global peace were critical if India sought to grow economically and build its security.[61]

Nehru led India from Independence in 1947 to his death in 1964. Although he forged a domestic consensus on foreign policy, support for his world view was far from unanimous. There were many who disagreed with his basic premises or with specific elements of his policies. Some criticized him openly while others voiced their views only in private. Some dissenters stayed in the Congress party and tried to reform it from within; others founded new parties after Independence to advance their alternative viewpoints.

A major rival to Nehru in defining India's external relations was Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel, India's first deputy prime minister and home minister. Patel was a foreign policy realist who often disagreed with Nehru though he expressed this disagreement in private or through letters the two wrote to each other until Patel's death in 1950. While agreeing that India needed to avoid being involved in power politics, Patel was amongst those who deemed a pro-Western orientation was to India's advantage. He argued that India needed strong ties with the United States more than the formal association with the British Commonwealth and asserted that 'we depend on the USA more than on the UK'.[62]